

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 4 of 6 — Settling into strength

Postpartum Week 27

"Ordinary greens and a little oil, doing quiet work in the background."

Weekly nourishment theme

Vitamin K, a quiet role in blood clotting and bone health

"Ordinary greens and a little oil, doing quiet work in the background."

Why it matters now

Vitamin K helps your body make proteins your blood needs to clot properly, including prothrombin, and also plays a role in normal bone metabolism. Without enough vitamin K, blood takes longer to clot — though this is genuinely rare in adults eating a varied diet.

Vitamin K participates in normal bone metabolism, but this does not mean that taking extra vitamin K has been proven to strengthen bones in an otherwise well-nourished mother.

Your daily reference: ICMR-NIN's 2020 report gives a general adult reference of 55 mcg a day, in line with FAO/WHO's own recommendation, with no separate figure for pregnancy or lactation. NIH's US reference is 90 mcg a day for an adult woman 19 and older, whether pregnant, breastfeeding, or neither — the same figure at every stage (75 mcg a day for ages 14-18). These are two different reference systems, presented honestly rather than reconciled into one number.

If you are breastfeeding or expressing milk: If you're breastfeeding or expressing milk, NIH's reference stays at 90 mcg a day — unchanged from pregnancy or non-pregnancy. ICMR-NIN doesn't publish a separate breastfeeding figure, so its general 55 mcg a day reference applies. A regular pattern including leafy greens and vegetable oils contributes meaningfully without needing exact counting.

If you are not breastfeeding: If you're not breastfeeding, vitamin K remains useful for normal blood clotting and bone metabolism, and your daily reference returns to the general adult figure — which for vitamin K doesn't actually change either way.

Where vitamin K comes from: Leafy green vegetables — spinach, methi, mustard greens, cabbage, and broccoli — and vegetable oils are the most reliable sources of vitamin K. Smaller amounts come from some fruits, and modest amounts come from meat, eggs, and dairy. Vitamin K is fat-soluble, so eating greens as part of a meal containing a modest amount of fat can support absorption. This does not require extra ghee or oil — use the cooking fat and quantity that already suit your household, preferences, and medical guidance.

A gentle note for this week: No upper limit has been established for naturally occurring vitamin K because adverse effects from ordinary food intake have not been identified. This does not make unnecessary supplementation beneficial, and supplemental vitamin K can interfere with warfarin and other vitamin K antagonists. Do not add a vitamin K product solely for this week's theme.

This week's rhythm: When leafy greens, cabbage, or other vitamin K-containing vegetables are already part of your household meals, they can contribute substantially without exact counting.

Each day below offers two options for every meal — pick whichever suits you. Vitamin K shows up naturally across many of this week's choices, so no single meal needs to carry the whole day.

If you are managing a health condition

- Taking warfarin or another vitamin K antagonist: If you take warfarin or another vitamin K antagonist, consistency matters more than avoidance. Keep your usual pattern of leafy greens and other vitamin K-containing foods reasonably steady rather than suddenly eating much more, much less, or cutting them out. Attend prescribed INR monitoring and contact your anticoagulation team when making a substantial dietary or supplement change. Do not stop or alter the medicine yourself. Other anticoagulants work differently — don't change your diet based on this section unless your prescriber or anticoagulation team has confirmed that vitamin K affects your medicine.
- A malabsorption condition (such as celiac disease, cystic fibrosis, or inflammatory bowel disease), or previous bariatric surgery: These conditions can genuinely affect how well you absorb vitamin K and other fat-soluble vitamins. Follow the specific monitoring and guidance your treating team has given you rather than this general chart.
- Thyroid conditions, high blood pressure, previous pre-eclampsia, diabetes, recent gestational diabetes, or PCOS: These don't require a special restriction on ordinary vitamin K-containing foods. Continue the eating pattern, medication, and monitoring already advised for your condition.

Day 1 — Anchor

Vitamin K helps your body make proteins your blood needs to clot properly, including prothrombin, and also plays a role in normal bone metabolism. Without enough vitamin K, blood takes longer to clot — though this is genuinely rare in adults eating a varied diet.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Methi thepla (whole-wheat) with curd.
- B. Boiled egg (cooked through) with whole-wheat toast.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with palak dal and a seasonal vegetable side.
- B. Chicken curry (cooked through) with rice and a cauliflower sabzi.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. Roasted chana with a guava.
- B. A small bowl of curd with a seasonal fruit.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Vegetable khichdi with peas, carrot, and a side of curd.
- B. A curry made with a locally available fish from the lower-mercury category, with rice and a cucumber salad.

If you're still hungry: Whatever's easiest to reach for right now.

Day 2 — A steady reference, pregnancy through breastfeeding

NIH's reference for vitamin K doesn't change at all across pregnancy, breastfeeding, or non-pregnancy — 90 mcg a day at every stage for an adult woman. ICMR-NIN's general 55 mcg a day reference is the same throughout too. A regular pattern including leafy greens and cooking oil contributes meaningfully without needing exact counting.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable oats porridge with roasted peanuts.
- B. Masala omelette (two eggs, cooked through) with whole-wheat toast.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Bajra roti with a moong dal and a beans sabzi.
- B. Mutton curry (cooked through) with rice and a cauliflower sabzi.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd with sunflower seeds.
- B. Roasted almonds with an orange.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Brown rice with a masoor dal and a sautéed spinach sabzi.
- B. Chicken curry (cooked through) with rice and a broccoli sabzi.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack.

About a vitamin K supplement: There's no need to add a separate vitamin K supplement based on this week's theme — food comfortably covers this nutrient for most mothers. If you take warfarin or another vitamin K antagonist, don't start any new supplement, including a multivitamin, without checking with your prescriber first.

Day 3 — Where vitamin K naturally shows up

Leafy greens and vegetable oils both matter today. Vitamin K is fat-soluble, so eating greens as part of a meal with even a modest amount of fat helps your body absorb it — no need to add extra oil or ghee beyond what your meal already has.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable daliya with roasted peanuts.
- B. Egg bhurji with whole-wheat toast.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with a methi-and-moong dal and a small bowl of curd.
- B. Grilled or pan-cooked lower-mercury fish (cooked through) with rice and a broccoli sabzi.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. Roasted cashews with a papaya.
- B. A small bowl of yogurt with a seasonal fruit.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Millet khichdi with a moong dal and a cauliflower sabzi.
- B. Mutton curry (cooked through) with rice and a beans sabzi.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack.

If you have a diagnosed allergy: If you have a diagnosed egg, dairy, nut, seed, fish or seafood allergy, avoid that food completely and choose a tolerated alternative from this week's chart. If a food causes digestive discomfort rather than an allergy, use only forms and portions you already know you tolerate. Do not trial a problem food to pursue this week's nutrient.

Day 4 — Newborn vitamin K, explained

You may remember your baby receiving vitamin K shortly after birth. Newborns naturally have low vitamin K stores because placental transfer is limited, and breast milk naturally contains relatively little vitamin K. This is normal physiology — not a problem with your milk and not something you caused. The newborn vitamin K dose prevents a rare but potentially serious bleeding disorder; it cannot be replaced by increasing the mother's dietary vitamin K or taking a maternal supplement.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable upma with roasted peanuts.
- B. Chicken sandwich (whole-wheat bread, fully cooked chicken) with a tomato side.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Jowar roti with a rajma curry and a beans sabzi.
- B. Mutton curry (cooked through) with rice and a broccoli sabzi.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. Sunflower seeds with a guava.
- B. A small bowl of curd with almonds.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti, a moong dal, and a potato sabzi.
- B. A curry made with a locally available fish from the lower-mercury category, with rice and a cabbage sabzi.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack.

If you're unsure whether your baby received vitamin K: If you are unsure whether your baby received vitamin K, or it was declined, contact your baby's clinician for advice rather than trying to compensate through your own diet or supplements.

Get urgent pediatric care if your baby shows: Seek urgent pediatric care for unexplained bruising or bleeding, blood in vomit or stool, unusual pallor, marked sleepiness, repeated vomiting, seizures, or a bulging soft spot. These signs can have several causes and require urgent assessment.

Day 5 — If you take warfarin or another vitamin K antagonist

If you take warfarin or another vitamin K antagonist, your vitamin K intake matters in a specific way — not because vitamin K is dangerous, but because these medicines work by opposing it, so a sudden change in how much you eat can affect how well your medicine is working. See the note below if this applies to you; for most other mothers, there's nothing special to adjust this week.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable uttapam with a small bowl of curd.
- B. Egg paratha (whole-wheat) with a side of curd.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with a masoor dal and a potato sabzi.
- B. Chicken curry (cooked through) with rice and a green-peas sabzi.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. Roasted chana with an orange.
- B. A small bowl of yogurt with sunflower seeds.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti, a moong dal, and a beans sabzi.
- B. Mutton curry (cooked through) with rice and a tomato salad.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack.

Day 6 — Away from home

Roasted chana, sunflower seeds, and cashews are naturally easy to carry today — no cold storage needed for these.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. A whole-wheat vegetable sandwich with lettuce and a slice of cheese.
- B. An egg-and-vegetable whole-wheat wrap (egg cooked through), carried in an insulated bag with an ice pack, kept cold until eaten.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. A roasted-chana-and-vegetable whole-wheat wrap, carried in an insulated bag with an ice pack, kept cold until eaten.
- B. A pre-made chicken sandwich (whole-wheat bread, fully cooked chicken), carried in an insulated bag with an ice pack, kept cold until eaten, with a tomato side.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A roasted chana-and-seed trail mix, kept portable — no cold storage needed.
- B. A small flask of buttermilk, kept cold.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. A reheated moong dal-and-vegetable curry with rice.
- B. A reheated mutton curry with rice and a vegetable side.

If you're still hungry: Whatever's already within reach.

Food safety: Keep the egg, chicken, and cheese sandwiches, and the flask of buttermilk, refrigerated or in an insulated bag with an ice pack, and make sure they stay cold until you actually eat or drink them — discard anything that's been sitting out at room temperature for more than about two hours (about one hour in hot weather). Roasted chana, sunflower seeds, and cashews are shelf-stable and don't need the same cold-chain care. Reheat the dal curry or mutton curry until steaming hot before eating.

Day 7 — Reflection

A quiet week to notice what already felt manageable, and what you'd want to carry into the weeks ahead.

Breakfast: Whichever breakfast felt best this week — worth repeating.

Lunch: Whichever lunch from this week you'd want again.

Nourishment break: Whichever snack worked best for you this week.

Dinner: Whichever dinner from this week you'd want again.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack, whatever suits you.

A new phase begins here — Settling into strength. The weeks behind you were about steady rebuilding; the months ahead are about consolidating that strength into a rhythm you can sustain.

Gentle weekly reflection

Did learning about the newborn vitamin K injection change how you think about that early moment after birth?

Looking ahead

Next week, we'll look at another nutrient as you settle into this next stretch of strength.

Food safety basics

- Cook eggs, meat, and fish all the way through — no runny yolks or pink centres.
- Cook sprouts before eating them. Raw sprouts carry a real risk of bacteria that washing doesn't remove — skip them raw entirely.
- Choose pasteurized milk, curd, and paneer.
- Wash fruits and vegetables well.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. If the source is uncertain, boil it or use a purifier suitable for the local water risk, and avoid ice from unknown sources when eating out.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding, unless your maternity team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding. If you choose to drink, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose lower-mercury fish and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.